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Dahomey, an ancient West African kingdom

Author(S): Herskovits, Melville J. (Melville Jean)

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Chapter XV : CICATRIZATION AND CIRCUMCISION

The following account of the manner in which circumcision is done on a boy of adolescent age was given by women informants, and may be presented before the version obtained from men is recounted. The boys of a village who are to be operated on are gathered in one compound, usually that of the man who is to be the operator. Each is seated naked, with legs outstretched, before a small hole dug in the earth, the organ resting in the hole. Any charms which boys have on their persons are removed before the operation. The ceremony is public, and friends and relatives stand about teasing the boys and joking with them, in order to dissipate any squeamishness, and more than that, to make them ashamed of showing fear. The operation is performed either with a sharp knife of native manufacture or a European razor, the instrument not being regarded as of ceremonial significance. The operator, according to this account, goes through some horse-play with the boys before he actually operates. He may, for example, take hold of the foreskin and tug at it, all the while watching his charge to see if the boy is nervous; and then tug harder still, or he will place the knife on the thigh of his subject, and look into his face to see if he shows fear. Meanwhile the bystanders fire a barrage of teasing exclamations, and otherwise impress on the boy the matter-of-factness of the operation. Finally the specialist takes hold of the foreskin, tugs at it several times, and then severs it with one stroke, letting the blood and the prepuce fall into the hole. The operator has medicine at hand to stanch the flow of blood if a severe hemorrhage ensues. When bleeding ceases, the operator pinches the organ so that scar-tissue does not form, and the boy is taken home. A boy who shows great courage and insists that he does not wish to be held during the operation enjoys much prestige among his group, and is not unlikely to swagger a bit for some time after. Ordinarily, two men are beside each boy, holding his shoulders to steady him. The wound is washed on the third day, and again the organ is pinched so that undue scarification will not occur, and

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this is repeated daily until the wound is healed. The operation is performed even if a boy shows great fear, but in such a case he is held by men who are there for this purpose. The boys receive no new name after circumcision, nor does  297 the hole that receives the blood and the foreskin have any ceremonial significance for them. However, before the operation is performed, each family makes whatever sacrifices are prescribed by their diviner, giving the offerings to those deities indicated by him as the proper ones to receive them. All the family gods are given food as well, and asked to watch over the life of the boy. The healing process is a matter of thirty days or more, if rapid, or about three months if recovery is slow, and it is said that an appreciable mortality is attendant on circumcision.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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